

Paper A: Listening into Writing — Class Feedback

This is general feedback for the whole class. Read it alongside your individual comments.

What the class did well

- **Opening moves.** Most of you set up the source properly in the first sentence or two.
- **The central argument.** Most of you identified the argument that, as the evidence has become visible, outright denial has given way to softer tactics and could name at least three of the four "D" tactics.
- **Reporting language.** There was a good variety of reporting verbs (*argues, contends, maintains, highlights*), and many of you used author–date citations consistently to distinguish Mann's claims from Spring's.
- **Real criticality in the strongest scripts.** There were some good critiques. For example, that the four-tactic framework explains how obstructive narratives are produced but not why audiences accept them, or that the framework risks classifying reasonable public concerns about energy costs as deliberate obstruction.

What could have been improved

- **Accuracy**

What some scripts said	What the podcast actually said
The most powerful individual action is cutting your own carbon footprint	The most powerful individual action is voting and holding policymakers accountable — focusing on your own footprint is the <i>deflection</i> tactic
The Australian bushfires were caused by arson	Arson was the misinformation claim Mann was refuting
Spring identifies the four tactics	Mann identifies them; Spring introduces and questions them

- **Summarising the main points rather than retelling the podcasts**

If your paragraphs begin *At the beginning... Then... Secondly... At the end...*, you are in danger of describing the podcast's **structure** rather than its **argument**. This means the marker can't see that you know which points are central and which are supporting detail. For example, in some cases, this meant the Australia anecdote and the white-powder envelope took up 40–50% of your word count.

Paper A: Listening into Writing — Stronger & Weaker Versions

A. The body of the summary

Weaker version

At the beginning of the podcast, Professor Mann talks about his experience in Australia during the Black Summer of 2019–2020. He explains that the heat and drought were unprecedented and that it was dangerous to go outside, like a scene from a Hollywood film. He says that studying climate change is very different from living it. Then he talks about his hockey stick graph from 1998, and how he was attacked by deniers because of his ethnic background, and even received an envelope containing white powder, so the FBI had to come. After that, the journalist asks him about the four tactics. These are delay, division, deflection and doomism. Finally, he says that our secret weapon is the moral authority of our children.

Stronger version

Mann's central claim is that opposition to climate action has not disappeared but changed form: because the effects of warming are now visible, fossil-fuel interests can no longer deny the phenomenon outright, so they work instead to prevent a response. He groups these newer strategies into four: delay, which concedes the problem but denies its urgency; division, which sets campaigners against one another over personal lifestyle choices; deflection, which relocates responsibility from policy to individual behaviour; and doomism, which claims the situation is already unsalvageable. All four, he argues, converge on the same outcome — inaction. His own experience of the Australian bushfires, and of two decades of personal attacks following his 1998 temperature study, is offered as illustration of how the terrain has shifted.

What changes between them

	Weaker	Stronger
Organising principle	The running order of the audio	The logic of the argument
Anecdote	Roughly half the word count	One sentence, subordinated to the claim
The four tactics	Listed as labels only	Each defined, and the shared effect stated
Signposting	<i>At the beginning... Then... After that... Finally</i>	<i>central claim... he groups... all four... is offered as</i>

Notice that the stronger version is not longer and does not contain more information. It contains *less* — but it shows the marker that the writer can tell a main point from a supporting detail.

B. The evaluation

Weaker version

Overall, this podcast is very convincing. This is because Professor Mann is a leading climate scientist who has studied this topic for decades, and the BBC is a reliable and credible news organisation. He also uses a lot of data, figures and statistics to support his arguments, which makes them persuasive. Moreover, the information is up to date because the situation has not changed much since then. However, the podcast could be improved if it gave more examples and evidence.

Stronger version

The typology is a useful account of how obstruction now operates, and the treatment of deflection is the most persuasive element: it explains why rising public awareness has not translated into proportionate policy change. The argument is weaker, however, on causation. Mann asserts that these tactics produce disengagement but offers illustration rather than evidence — a single activist's testimony and one TikTok clip — and the framework describes how such messages are produced without addressing why particular audiences find them convincing. Political distrust and economic insecurity may matter as much as coordinated messaging. There is also a risk of over-attribution: public anxiety about energy costs is treated as obstruction rather than as a concern that climate policy has to answer.

What changes between them

	Weaker	Stronger
Object of evaluation	The speaker and the broadcaster	The argument
Accuracy	Credits data and statistics that are not in the source	Names the evidence that is actually offered
Criticism	Generic (<i>more examples needed</i>)	Specific and located
Support	Assertion without evidence (<i>not changed much since then</i>)	Reasoning the marker can follow

The weaker evaluation could be pasted onto a summary of almost any podcast. The stronger one could only have been written about this one.

EXAMPLE 1 — around the 60–65 band



In this BBC podcast, the journalist Marianna Spring interviews the climate scientist Professor Michael Mann about climate change deniers.

At the beginning, Mann describes his sabbatical in Australia during the Black Summer of 2019–2020. Unprecedented heat and drought caused enormous bushfires, and on many days it was dangerous to go outside. He explains that studying climate change is very different from living through it. He then discusses the graph he published in 1998, known as the hockey stick, which showed that global temperatures were rising and human activity was to blame. After this, he was attacked by deniers, who referred to his ethnic background and even sent him an envelope of white powder.

Next, the journalist introduces four tactics used by deniers: delay, division, deflection and doomism. Mann argues that the most powerful action is for individuals to reduce their own carbon footprint, for example by recycling and changing their travel plans. He also mentions social media, and the podcast interviews a British climate activist who receives abuse online. Finally, Mann says that our secret weapon is the moral authority of our children.

Overall, this podcast is convincing because Mann is a leading scientist who has researched climate change for decades, and the BBC is a credible news source. He supports his argument with a lot of data and statistics. In my opinion, the podcast is also up to date, because the situation has not changed since then. However, it would be stronger with more examples. We must all take action now for the sake of future generations. (292 words)

EXAMPLE 2 — around the 75+ band

Mann's central claim in this BBC interview is that opposition to climate action has not disappeared but changed form. Drawing on his experience of the Australian bushfires, he argues that as warming becomes harder to deny, fossil-fuel interests increasingly shift from challenging the science to blocking policy action.

Mann identifies four strategies. Delay accepts that warming is real but denies the need for urgent action. Division shifts attention to arguments between campaigners about lifestyle choices. Deflection moves responsibility away from policy and onto individual behaviour, such as recycling. Doomism, which Mann presents as a reversed form of denial, claims that the crisis is already beyond repair.

Although the four tactics differ, Mann argues that they all have the same effect: they delay action. He does not reject individual behaviour, but claims that the most important individual action is political, because only governments can introduce carbon pricing or restrict new fossil-fuel infrastructure. Spring adds that these narratives spread mainly through social media, where young activists, especially young women, face racist and misogynistic abuse designed to push them out of the debate.

The discussion of deflection is the strongest part of the argument because it explains why greater public concern has not led to equivalent policy change. However, Mann's causal claim is less convincing: he asserts that these tactics create disengagement but supports this mainly with one activist's testimony and a single social-media clip. The framework also explains how obstructive messages are produced, but not why audiences accept them; institutional distrust and economic



insecurity may be equally important. Finally, because the podcast was recorded shortly before COP26, its closing optimism can now be judged against later events. (275 words)

Comments

Example 2 is stronger because it focuses on the speaker's **main argument** rather than simply describing what happened in the podcast. It identifies Mann's key claim that climate change denial has evolved into new forms such as delay, division, deflection and doomism. It also **synthesises** information by grouping related ideas together instead of following the podcast in chronological order. This helps the reader understand the overall message more clearly.

Most importantly, Example 2 includes **critical evaluation**. It comments on the strengths of the argument and questions whether the evidence is sufficient to support some of Mann's claims. This shows analysis rather than simple agreement. In contrast, Example 1 mainly retells the content of the podcast and ends with the writer's personal opinion ("We must all take action now"), which is not the purpose of a critical summary. A critical summary should evaluate the source's argument, evidence and reasoning, rather than promote the writer's own views.

In short: Example 1 is mostly a descriptive summary, while Example 2 demonstrates the summary, synthesis and critical evaluation expected in academic critical summary writing.